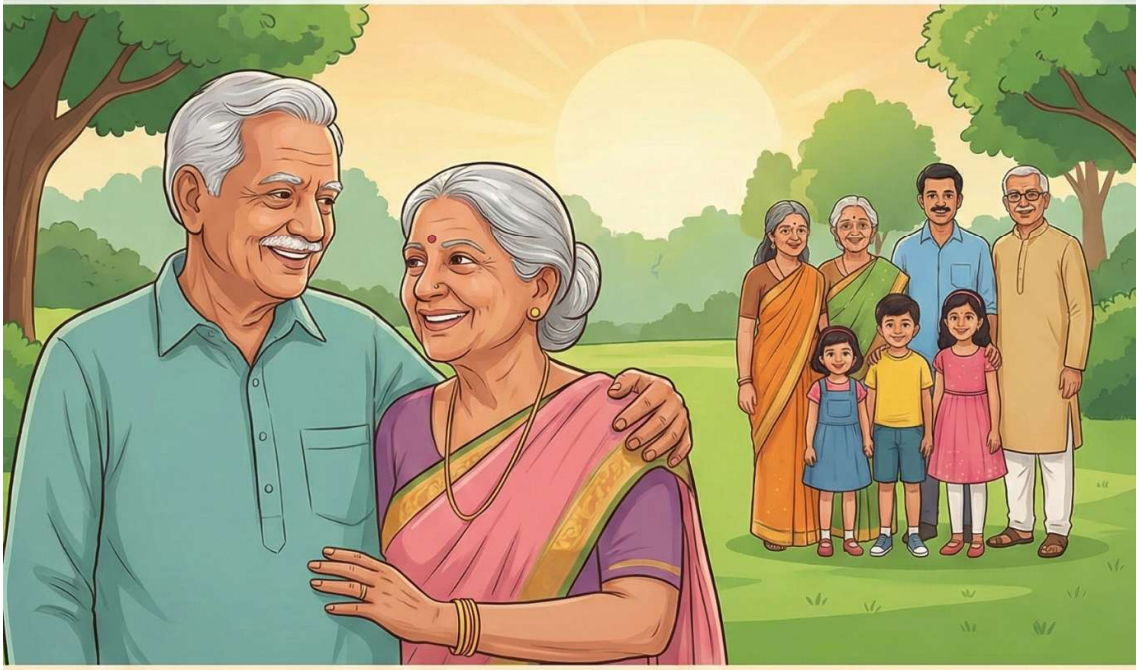
HEALTHY & SAFE AGEING

A Complete Reference for Senior Citizens, Caregivers & Health Workers

Prepared Using Trusted References From:
Ministry of Health & Family Welfare (MoHFW, India) | WHO | AIIMS | HelpAge India
ICMR/Public Health Nutrition | First Aid Manuals | Yoga & Well-Being Guides



Audience: Elderly individuals (≥60 years), caregivers, families, community health workers

1. Introduction & Overview

1.1 What Is Healthy Ageing?

Healthy ageing means maintaining **physical health, mental well-being, independence, mobility, social engagement and quality of life** as we grow older. It combines disease prevention, lifestyle choices, and safe living environments to improve **well-being in later years**. (World Health Organization)

1.2 Demographics in India

India has a rapidly growing elderly population — projected to rise significantly over the next decades — creating a need for comprehensive care systems. (World Health Organization)

1.3 National Policy & Support Systems

India's health policy for seniors operates through:

- **Maintenance & Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Act (2007)**
- **National Programme for Health Care of the Elderly (NPHCE)** which provides **primary to tertiary care, specialized clinics, and training for geriatric care** across government facilities. (Directorate General of Health Services)

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2. Health & Wellness Fundamentals

2.1 Regular Health Assessments

Elderly persons should schedule periodic check-ups for:

- Blood pressure monitoring
- Diabetes screening
- Eye and hearing tests
- Heart health
- Cognitive/memory evaluation
- Bone/joint health

These help with **early detection of chronic conditions** and prevent complications.

2.2 Prevention of Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs)

Common conditions include hypertension, diabetes, heart disease, arthritis, and respiratory issues. A healthy lifestyle — including diet, physical activity, and regular healthcare — reduces risks significantly.

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3. Managing Common Health Conditions

3.1 Blood Pressure (Hypertension)

High blood pressure is common with age.
Management strategies:

- Reduce dietary salt
- Adopt moderate physical activity
- Regular medication adherence
- Regular BP monitoring

Lifestyle changes plus medicine can control BP and reduce stroke/heart attack risk.

3.2 Diabetes Mellitus

Older adults often develop Type 2 diabetes.
Key points:

- Balanced meals with whole grains, legumes and vegetables
- Consistent mealtimes
- Monitor blood sugar (glucometer)
- Foot care (inspect feet daily)
- Regular doctor visits

Managing stress and staying active can improve glucose control.

3.3 Arthritis & Joint Pain

Arthritis causes joint stiffness and pain.
Helpful measures include:

- Gentle range-of-motion exercises
- Warm compresses

- Maintaining healthy weight
- Avoiding prolonged sitting

Seek physiotherapy if pain limits daily life.

3.4 Vision & Hearing

Ageing increases cataracts, glaucoma, and hearing loss.

Prevention and treatment:

- Regular eye check-ups
- Hearing tests
- Protective eyewear outdoors

Early treatment can preserve function.

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4. Daily Physical Activity

WHO recommends:
Older adults should aim for at least **150 minutes of moderate aerobic activity** per week (e.g., brisk walking), along with muscle strengthening and balance training. (oldagesolutions.org)

4.1 Safe Home Activities

✓ Walking inside the house or garden
✓ Chair exercises
✓ Simple balance and stretching movements

Avoid high-impact or high-intensity workouts without medical clearance.

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5. Yoga, Breathing & Mind–Body Wellness

Yoga can improve balance, flexibility, and stress levels.
Gentle practices like **Tadasana, Sukhasana, and Anulom Vilom breathing** can be included. Always practice in a safe, non-slippery space. (aam.mohfw.gov.in)

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6. Medications & Safety

6.1 Safe Medication Practices

- Maintain an up-to-date **medication list**
- Use **pill organizers**
- Don't skip doses or double-dose
- Review medicines regularly with a healthcare provider

6.2 How to Store Medicines

- Store in **cool, dry place**
- Keep all medicines in original packaging
- Separate emergency vs daily medications
- Check **expiry dates** frequently

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7. Nutrition & Hydration

Aging changes nutritional requirements; energy needs often decline, but **vitamins and minerals remain crucial**. (PMC)

7.1 Balanced Nutrition

Include:

- Whole grains (roti, rice, millets)
- Pulses and legumes
- Fruits and vegetables
- Dairy or alternatives for calcium
- Proteins like lentils, eggs, paneer

Micronutrient focus:
Many elderly in India have deficiencies in **Vitamin D, B12, calcium and folate** which affect bone and cognitive health. (ORF Online)

7.2 Hydration

Drink 6–8 glasses daily. Increase fluids on hot days. Avoid excessive caffeine.

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8. Sleep & Mental Well-Being

8.1 Sleep Hygiene

- Go to bed and wake up at same time

- Avoid stimulants (tea/coffee) before bed
- Ensure quiet, cool room

8.2 Emotional & Cognitive Health

Stay engaged socially through community groups, family time or hobbies. Loneliness affects many seniors and can impact physical wellness.

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9. Home Safety & Fall Prevention

Falls are a major risk for older adults.

Key Preventive Tips

- Non-slip mats in bathrooms
- Clear walkways
- Good lighting
- Handrails on stairs
- Mobility aids if needed

Regular balance and strength exercises reduce fall risk.

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10. First Aid & Emergency Protocols

10.1 Household First Aid Kit

A basic kit may include:

- Sterile dressings
- Adhesive tape
- Antiseptic wipes
- Digital thermometer
- Pain relievers
- Emergency contacts

(Refer to standard first aid manuals.) (Scribd)

10.2 What to Do in Emergencies

Chest Pain (Possible Heart Attack):

- Stop activity, stay calm
- Call **112** immediately
- If trained, start CPR

Falls & Injuries:

- Don't rush to stand
- Check for pain, bleeding
- Call for help if injured

Dizziness, Collapse, Bleeding:

- Sit or lie down
- Elevate legs
- Drink water if conscious

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11. When to Seek Medical Help

Call the Doctor

- New or worsening pain
- Persistent fever
- Unusual fatigue

Call Emergency Services (112)

- Severe chest pain
- Sudden breathlessness
- Uncontrolled bleeding
- Loss of consciousness

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12. Support Services & Rights in India

Government Programs

- **NPHCE** — dedicated elderly healthcare at primary/secondary/tertiary levels. (Directorate General of Health Services)

- Pensions and senior citizen benefits
- Fast-track judicial provisions for seniors

NGO Support

- **HelpAge India** provides elder help desks in hospitals, counselling, and assistance with services. (HelpAge India)